DUOLINGO: Research & Audit

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Overview

In educational technology, Duolingo is a paragon of innovation and accessibility. Founded in 2011 by Luis von Ahn and Severin Hacker, Duolingo has since embarked on a mission to provide free language education to the world. Its unique approach combines technology with gamification, making learning not just accessible but also engaging and enjoyable. This will cover Duolingo's objectives, its audience, competitive landscape, current situation, and the opportunities and challenges it faces, positioning it within the broader context of social media management and digital education.

Objective and Mission

At its core, Duolingo is more than just a language learning app; it's a movement towards democratizing education. By offering its services for free, Duolingo breaks down barriers to education, enabling people from all walks of life to learn new languages, expand their horizons, and open up new opportunities. With over 40 languages available, from Spanish and French to Navajo and Hawaiian, Duolingo caters to a vast audience with diverse learning needs and interests.

Target Audience

Duolingo's primary public includes individual learners, educators, subscribers to its Plus service, and investors. Learners range from young students to adults seeking personal or professional development. Educators use Duolingo as a supplementary tool, integrating it into language curriculums to enhance learning outcomes. Subscribers who opt for Duolingo Plus seek a more

enriched learning experience, free from advertisements, with additional features like offline lessons. Investors and stakeholders are also crucial to Duolingo, especially after its IPO in 2021, emphasizing its role as a significant player in the tech industry.

Competitive Landscape

The language learning app market is crowded, with competitors like Babbel, Rosetta Stone, Memrise, and Busuu offering various methodologies and features. Babbel focuses on conversational skills, Rosetta Stone on immersion, Memrise on memorization techniques, and Busuu on social learning. Despite these competitors, Duolingo's unique selling proposition—its gamified learning experience—sets it apart, making language learning addictive and fun.

Current Situation and Growth

Duolingo has shown remarkable growth, with millions of active users worldwide. Its success lies in continuous innovation, such as introducing new languages, enhancing the user interface, and incorporating cutting-edge technologies like AI to personalize learning experiences. The launch of Duolingo ABC for literacy and Stories for contextual learning signifies its expansion beyond mere language learning into broader educational domains.

Opportunities

The future holds numerous opportunities for Duolingo. Expanding its language portfolio to include more indigenous and less commonly taught languages can attract a niche audience. Leveraging AI and machine learning can further personalize the learning experience, adapting it to individual users' learning styles and pace. Educational partnerships can elevate Duolingo's status as a legitimate tool for language proficiency certification, opening doors to academic and professional markets.

Challenges

However, challenges abound. While central to Duolingo's mission, the freemium model necessitates a delicate balance to encourage upgrades to Plus without undermining the free user experience. In a saturated market, differentiation becomes paramount, requiring constant innovation and user engagement strategies. Maintaining user motivation over time is another hurdle, as language learning demands long-term commitment and regular practice.

Content Analysis

Duolingo has claimed virtually every "@Duolingo" handle on every social media. As a multi-lingual corporation, they went the extra mile to create sub-pages for different languages. Their cross-platform consistency is also maintained through identical profile pictures and similar bios, making them very identifiable. To trademark their posts, they include keywords like "duo" and "lingo" as play-on-words of their brand. As a playful presence online, they stick with the times and codeswitch based on trends. Links to their website are included in every bio, some for the general site and some for merchandising.

1) <u>TikTok (Duolingo, n.d):</u>

Duolingo has 9.4 million followers on TikTok. Duolingo posts about every other day. This is surprising considering the large followership. When it is a posting day, there are usually two posts. TikTok does not allow for easy analysis of finding the time of day a post was made. However, on February 7th, they posted 2 videos an hour apart at around 2 PM. They share a lot of recorded or edited videos and carousel posts on their TikTok. The posts consist of entertainment media. This contradicts many other companies' approaches because the others are usually not as indirect in their promotion. The main topics addressed in Duolingo's

TikTok are trends and popular culture fused with their unique use of symbolism. When something is relevant online, they are quick to take inspiration from it. Their engagement rates seem to be dependent on the popularity of the topic they share. When it is not about anything specific and is meant to be a general joke, it is a hit or miss. The ones that hit are sharable and snackable. Replayability and shareability are vital in their content. Duolingo is very patient and relaxed when it comes to posting schedules. They also have content that can only be found on TikTok.

2) Facebook (Duolingo, n.d):

Duolingo has 2.2 million followers on Facebook. Out of their main social media pages, Duolingo posts the least frequently here. There is no set schedule for post dates or times. The general consistency is about 1-2 posts every week. 9 AM – 12 PM and 3 PM – 7 PM are popular ranges. For the most part, they post cartoon pictures with captions. Every so often, they will post a cartoon video, but rarely any live footage. Facebook appears to be Duolingo's news outlet and holiday celebration hub. Whenever they have a new feature coming out, or they have an event, such as Duocon, they post it here with a nice and straightforward caption. Engagements on holiday/event posts are the best compared to other ones. However, there is no defined pattern for the success of the other posts because they do not focus on memes or entertainment content on this social media platform. Their content seems to be more curated for an older audience than other platforms. The type of content Duolingo shares elsewhere is not popular among Facebook's demographic, so they strategize a lot differently here.

3) Instagram (Duolingo, n.d):

Duolingo has 1.8 million followers on Instagram. Posts on Instagram vary day by day. As of recent weeks, Duolingo posts at least 1 photo/reel a day except for Sundays and sometimes Saturdays. After shallow observation, the most activity seen in one day was 4 posts. Duolingo posts in the mornings and evenings, favoring 8 AM-11 AM or 6 PM-11 PM EST. Most posts comprise of reels with the occasional image/slideshow post. Duolingo rarely directly promotes its product/service. However, they use symbolism and mascots in a meme or skit format. A lot of the topics surround trends or general jokes. There is no definite and discernable pattern in engagement rates between posts. They do have a variety of content because the internet trends are everchanging, but it seems that the success of their posts relies on the amount of success the trend has. Also, their posts that have no call to action or call to respond appropriately have less engagement in terms of comments and likes. Unlike Twitter and Facebook, they are much more visual in their presentation of content. Some content is even curated for people to post to an Instagram story.

4) Twitter (Duolingo, n.d):

Duolingo has 817.5 thousand followers on Twitter. Duolingo posts about as frequently as they do on Instagram, plus a few more every week. The times at which the post varies a lot more than Instagram because text-only tweets can be made in an instant. Over the past couple of weeks, they favor 9 AM - 11 AM, 1 PM - 4 PM, and 8 PM - 11 PM EST. Duolingo shares photos, text tweets, and videos on occasion. Some are even unseen on any other platform, so there is some degree of exclusivity in their Twitter community. Like Instagram and TikTok, their content on Twitter is less direct in their self-promotion. They are a meme-oriented page focusing on making posts that others can enjoy and perhaps retweet. Relatability is huge in their content here because of Twitter's retweet feature. When they post or make replies, it is

usually geared toward something that others can say "same here" to. Duolingo takes advantage of the simplicity of words on a screen. While a picture can mean a thousand words, a Tweet can create a domino effect of engagement.

Overall Content Analysis:

For the most part, Duolingo consistently demonstrates a playful tone online. Even Facebook, where they do not share memes, the cartoons create some kind of binding for the brand. The most engaging content overall was found to be relatable and snackable content because a company with an unhinged aesthetic is unexpected. TikTok is the most effective in terms of metrics since their engagements line up to a good ratio with their following compared to the other social media studied here. Duolingo may have an opportunity to capitalize on TikTok more because their relatively relaxed post schedule can be improved to push out more content.

Audience Analysis

- Demographics:
  - Duolingo is used by individuals who want to acquire a new language, with the largest age group of visitors being 18- to 24-year-olds (*Duolingo.com*, n.d.).
  - 18-24 (28.98%), 25-34 (25.67%), 35-44 (17.91%), 45-54 (12.59%), 55-64 (8.82%), 65+ (6.04%) (*Duolingo.com*, n.d.).
  - Duolingo's audience is 51.31% female and 48.69% male (*Duolingo.com*, n.d.).
  - Top 3 countries: United States (22.84%), Brazil (6.6%), and United Kingdom (4.64%) (*Duolingo.com*, n.d.).
- Client's Engagements:

- Duolingo seems to have a very active audience who engage often with their posts on various social media platforms, such as TikTok (9.4 million followers) and Instagram (1.8 million followers).
- With their predominately Gen Z audience, Duolingo has had immense success on newer platforms like TikTok. Duolingo has over 9.4 million followers on TikTok, which is much more than other popular brands on the platform, like Disney, Apple, Nike, and more (Woodbury, 2023). Across all posts on TikTok, they have received over 201.8 million likes.
- The comments and replies on most of the content posted by Duolingo seem to be very positive and demonstrate an active community of brand advocates.

- General mentions of @duolingo:
  - When asked about Duolingo, most people rate it with 4 or 5 stars, describing it as very functional and easy to use. The majority of reviews, comments, replies, and other general mentions online depict overall high satisfaction ratings (*Duolingo Reviews*, n.d.).
- Audience Tone:
  - Duolingo appears to have an overall very positive sentiment across various social media platforms, online discussions, and more (*Duolingo Reviews*, n.d.).
- Conversation Volume:
  - Over 500 million people use Duolingo around the globe, making the volume of conversations substantial (Piedrahíta, 2023).
  - In addition, Duolingo has 74.1 million Monthly Active Users and 21.4 million Daily Active Users who are invested in the content and generate a large portion of these conversations (Piedrahíta, 2023).

- Audience Key Findings and Application:
  - This information is useful because it allows us to better understand our target audience and create more engaging content that appeals to them more.
  - With this, we can tailor our content to appeal more to our most prominent demographics, which will allow us to not only maintain customer loyalty but grow our consumer base as well.

Competitor Analysis

1) Babbel

Facebook (Babbel)	Instagram (@babbel)	X (@babbel)	TikTok (@babbel)	YouTube (@BabbelPlus)
1.6M followers	314K followers	35.4K followers	213.3K followers	191K subscribers

a. Facebook (Babbel, n.d):

   i. Until November 27th, 2023, they posted daily at 9:00 AM, sharing fun language facts and promoting articles from their website. Each post received around 2 likes, but comments were mostly complaints about Babbel's customer service, urging others not to use the app. Their aim was to redirect viewers to their website and Babbel Magazine.

b. Instagram (Babbel, n.d):

   i. Posts frequently from 9:00 AM to 8:00 PM, often featuring lists, translations, and article references. Typical likes range from a few hundred, but one post had nearly 3,000 likes. Comments vary from 10 to 100, focusing on language discussion. Instagram reels get 40K views on average, with some reaching millions, but likes average around 5K.

Higher likes correlate with more comments, ranging from dozens to thousands.

c. X (Babbel, n.d):

i. Posts almost daily, occasionally missing a week; typically posts from 10:00 AM to 12:30 PM. Shares articles from their website focusing on language facts and studies. Minimal engagement with 1-3 reshares and 3-10 likes, aiming to drive traffic to their website.

d. TikTok (Babbel, n.d):

i. Posts nearly daily, usually mid-day, featuring word translations in various languages like on Instagram. Videos garner 10K-200K views, with some reaching 3M. Likes range from 2K-5K, and comments vary from 15-100 based on views. Videos aim to educate viewers in a fun way, often showcasing native language pronunciation.

e. YouTube (Babbel, n.d):

i. Posts 2-3 times monthly, usually mid-day, covering common errors, phrases, language similarities, etymology, and tips. Videos receive a few thousand views with 30-100 likes and fewer than 10 comments. Aim is language education with minimal self-promotion.

2) Rosetta Stone

Facebook (Rosetta Stone)	Instagram (@rosettastone)	X (@rosettastone)	TikTok (@rosettastone)	YouTube (@RosettaStone)
2.4M followers	63.7K followers	90.2K followers	58.5K followers	70.1K subscribers

a. Facebook (Rosetta Stone, n.d):

i. They post daily with tips, basic words/phrases, cultural holidays, and listicles of popular words in different languages. Averages 3-5 likes, occasionally 40, with few comments. Goal is language education with minimal self-promotion.

b. Instagram (Rosetta Stone, n.d):

i. They post daily with a variety of language-related content mirroring their Facebook posts. Normal posts get 10-60 likes and 2-5 comments; Instagram Reels get 10K-80K views. Reels average 800-3K likes and 20-100 comments, aiming to educate about languages and cultures in an engaging manner.

c. X (Rosetta Stone, n.d):

i. They post once or twice daily, sharing listicles, tips, cultural events, and language comparison videos. Posts typically receive 1-5 likes with some reposts but no comments. Their goal is to educate and promote articles from their website.

d. TikTok (Rosetta Stone, n.d):

i. They post once a day or every two days, usually mid-day, sharing tips, lists, stories, and quizzes. Views range from 2K-17K, with some videos more popular. Typically 40 to a few hundred likes and less than ten comments. Goal is fun, educational content for younger audiences, featuring tips and short language lessons.

e. YouTube (Rosetta Stone, n.d):

i. They post 4-5 videos monthly, with sporadic YouTube Shorts, usually mid-day. Content includes language tips, conjugation guides, overviews, and popular phrases. Normal videos get 500-1K views, Shorts around 200. Few comments and less than 100 likes per video. Goal is to share tips and educate about languages and conjugations.

Conclusion

Duolingo's integration of gamification with technology and its commitment to free language education for a global audience distinguish it in the market. This unique value proposition underpins its brand identity and market positioning. The platform's primary audience includes a significant portion of Generation Z, especially those aged 18-24. High engagement on social media platforms like TikTok and Instagram indicates a strong connection with this demographic, characterized by high satisfaction ratings and positive interactions. Duolingo's social media strategy is marked by consistency across platforms, the creation of playful and relatable content, and strategic tokenization. The brand's success on TikTok highlights an opportunity to capitalize on this platform to further engage the target audience. Duolingo stands out for its engagement levels on social networks, outperforming competitors like Babbel and Rosetta Stone. Insights into competitor strategies provide valuable benchmarks and areas for Duolingo to refine its approach. Expansion into new educational areas and leveraging AI for personalized learning represent avenues for growth. Partnerships for language proficiency certifications could enhance Duolingo's credibility and market influence.

Based on these insights, the proposed social media plan could include:

Amplify presence on TikTok to leverage its trend-setting capabilities and engage with the Gen Z audience through shareable, playful content. Tailor content to suit the unique characteristics of each social media platform, ensuring consistency with Duolingo's brand while appealing to the platform-specific audience. Stay ahead of the competition by exploring new content formats and trends, balancing educational and entertaining content to maintain audience engagement. Collaborate with educational institutions or certification bodies to bolster credibility and reach, using social media to promote these partnerships. Boost engagement by promoting user-generated content, such as contests or success stories, to foster a sense of community among users. Duolingo's online persona is engaging and attention-grabbing, with a successful meme and trend-centric strategy. However, a more selective approach to posting could improve brand perception, avoiding content that may be perceived as corny or unnecessary. Understanding the target audience, particularly Gen Z, is crucial for creating relevant and engaging content. Tailoring content to this demographic is a key strategy for attracting and retaining users. The lack of engagement by competitors like Babbel and Rosetta Stone highlights the importance of relatable and humorous content. Learning from competitors' shortcomings can guide Duolingo to better connect with its audience.

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